IO bureaucrats have access to the tools to counter populist pressures that we have described. For example, they can appease populists by tailoring conditions on loans, adjusting technical assistance programs, or prioritizing populists' concerns on organizational agendas. Judges, for example, may decline to rule against populist states to avoid escalation, while other staff might overlook rule violations.

They can also sideline populists by working creatively around uncooperative leaders, forming partnerships with other institutions, deepening ties with nonpopulist actors, or redirecting resources to initiatives less reliant on populist input. Bureaucrats can further sideline constituents by increasing reliance on secrecy mechanisms to shield IO operations from populist scrutiny or public backlash. Finally, they can appease constituents through their control of social media and public communication, which allows them to highlight the tangible benefits of IOs to win over skeptical domestic audiences.

Leaders of IOs face even greater visibility and accountability. As the public faces of their institutions, they are judged on their ability to navigate crises and achieve organizational mandates. Successful leadership can pave the way for future opportunities in domestic or international politics, further incentivizing leaders to thwart populist resistance.

Institutional leaders can pursue many of the same strategies of bureaucrats, though their influence over policymaking varies across institutions. In many cases, organizational leaders are figureheads with significant agenda-setting authority: They can instruct managers and bureaucrats to pursue certain initiatives or emphasize specific policy areas (Copelovitch and Rickard 2021). They may also publicly praise or criticize certain countries and governments—for example, NATO head Jens Stoltenberg credited Trump for pushing other NATO members to increase defense spending. While substantial changes to voting shares or institutional leadership positions typically require member state assent, leaders can sometimes dole out targeted benefits (e.g., encouraging staff to provide larger loans to certain countries) to appease populists, and they can forge cooperative agreements with other institutions as a part of a sidelining strategy. Finally, they can sideline constituents by increasing secrecy, establishing confidential channels to engage with populist states.